

Chapter 35 Part 2

The meeting lasted nearly an hour. Xu Qingzhu announced adjournment and told everyone to return to their respective positions to get busy. Everyone left the conference room one after another.

The department manager was eager to play matchmaker between Zhou Yi'an and Xu Qingzhu, leading Zhou Yi'an in front of Xu Qingzhu. "Since everyone was here earlier, I didn't introduce you properly. Let me formally introduce you now. This is our design department's deputy manager, also our Director Xu's daughter, Miss Xu Qingzhu. She graduated from Qingyi University¹ with a finance major, took an additional two years of MBA, and although she just graduated, she's very capable - you should have witnessed that earlier. And this is our new employee that Director Xu spent great effort to recruit, RT's annual emerging designer, Miss Zhou Yi'an."

Xu Qingzhu was organizing the documents on the table. Upon hearing this, she looked up and glanced over, seeing the department manager grinning like "a landlord's foolish son,"² completely oblivious to what was happening.

She sighed helplessly and extended her hand slightly. "Hello, Xu Qingzhu."

"Hello." Zhou Yi'an smiled. "It's not our first meeting. Why are you being so polite, Miss Xu?"

"You two know each other?" The department manager was surprised.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She really seriously doubted how someone with his intelligence managed to reach the department manager position.

He had even been in the marketing department before coming to the design department.

It could only be said that Minghui Jewelry's internal staff were all such "talents" - it would be hard not to go bankrupt.

Zhou Yi'an: "Of course."

Xu Qingzhu: "We've met once."

Both voices rang out simultaneously in the conference room. The department manager paused slightly. "So do you know each other or not?"

Xu Qingzhu frowned and couldn't help but retort, "Does it concern you?"

Her tone was relatively calm, but because she had a lot on her mind, it didn't sound particularly friendly.

"Department manager," Xu Qingzhu said, "Can we only discuss business matters in the company? Whether we have private relations or not isn't important."

The department manager was taken aback. This was the first time he'd seen Xu Qingzhu lose her temper, and he quickly said "okay" several times.

Xu Qingzhu walked toward the door. Zhou Yi'an took her hands out of her pants pockets and patted the department manager's shoulder, her tone teasing and mocking: "Department manager, you're a department manager after all. How could you just... emmm"

She didn't finish her sentence, just carried a smile that seemed meaningful.

Zhou Yi'an hadn't intended to avoid Xu Qingzhu hearing, so her voice wasn't quiet, and Xu Qingzhu heard it perfectly.

Upon hearing this, Xu Qingzhu stopped walking and turned back to look at Zhou Yi'an. "Miss Zhou, since you've joined Minghui Jewelry, you're an employee of Minghui Jewelry. Starting to provoke leadership relationships on your first day - is this because you're arrogant about your talents or do you want to be fired? Our design department is small and can't tolerate two-faced new employees. If you have other ideas, I can help you process your resignation."

"Ah? I'd be fine with that, but it depends on whether your father agrees." Zhou Yi'an shrugged indifferently. "No matter how capable a princess is, she still has to consider the emperor's wishes, right?"

After saying this, she frowned slightly, but her smile grew even brighter as she said without much apology: "Sorry, I'm just making an analogy. I didn't mean it that way."

"Well, I didn't know that Mr. Zhou would actually agree to let you come out to work." Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue, her voice cold and clear, her expression disdainful. "I thought princesses could only be kept at home."

She directly used Zhou Yi'an's words against her.

"Miss Zhou," Xu Qingzhu said, "If you're here to be a designer, then Minghui Jewelry welcomes you. If you're just here to play office palace intrigue, then sorry, we don't have the time or energy to play with you. You yourself are a high and mighty young lady who doesn't worry about food or clothing and doesn't know the hardships of common people, but the employees here all depend on this job to support their families. They have elderly parents and young children to care for - they're different from you."

She paused briefly, gently pressing her lips together, her voice becoming deeper. "The day Minghui Jewelry goes bankrupt, I'll send all the materials to Mr. Zhou. Not only that, all media will broadcast it together, including that day's recordings. You'll go from being an idle young miss to the executioner who caused a company's bankruptcy."

Zhou Yi'an's smile disappeared. "You!"

Xu Qingzhu said: "If Minghui Jewelry goes bankrupt, then I have nothing left to lose either. And that day's recordings can prove that you had the motive to do such a thing. Even if it was originally the already shaky Minghui Jewelry, as long as you joined, if this company goes bankrupt, it will definitely be related to you. Mr. Zhou has come this far and surely has quite a few enemies. Tell me, even if I let you go, will others let you go?"

Only five people remained in the large conference room.

Xu Qingzhu, the department manager, Zhou Yi'an, and Cherry and Sally.

Sally was completely confused, constantly tugging at Cherry's clothes asking what Xu Qingzhu was saying and whether they were fighting.

Cherry's mind worked quickly. Although her family couldn't compare to the Liang family, she had some connections to understand insider circle matters, and moreover - Zhou Yi'an.

Surnamed Zhou, how many people in all of Haichuan City³ could have the surname Zhou?

She naturally understood Zhou Yi'an's identity.

But she had no time to answer Sally's questions.

She was too busy enjoying the drama herself - how could she have time for her?

The department manager was completely confused: Where am I? What are they talking about? Why can't I understand? Minghui Company is going bankrupt? Why would it go bankrupt? Isn't it doing quite well now?

Department manager: ...Why is even the young miss's arguing so extraordinary?

Xu Qingzhu's words dropped a bombshell in Zhou Yi'an's heart.

She immediately frowned tightly.

"What do you say, Miss Zhou?" Xu Qingzhu asked calmly.

She was like a bamboo standing alone in the world⁴ - seemingly swaying in wind and rain, appearing to be on the verge of collapse, yet retaining a thread of vitality.

And this vitality was like sparks in spring - needing only to fall into wild grass to spread like wildfire in an instant.

Just like the current Minghui Jewelry.

Xu Qingzhu's tone was slow, and she didn't use her home field advantage to suppress Zhou Yi'an, nor did she show any fear.

She stated her viewpoint neither humbly nor arrogantly, while also elevating Zhou Yi'an and threatening her at the same time, bringing out the two great weapons of Zhou's father and the media to make Zhou Yi'an feel fearful.

Zhou Yi'an thought for a long time, then slowly walked over, getting extremely close to her.

Xu Qingzhu didn't like the smell on her - a heavy cigarette smell that was very choking.

Xu Qingzhu stepped back half a step.

Zhou Yi'an curved her lips into a light smile, smiling quite wickedly. "I think Miss Xu makes a lot of sense."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes were clear and transparent, yet also like unfathomable ocean depths, making it impossible to guess what she was thinking. Just looking over calmly was enough to make people feel pressure.

Zhou Yi'an didn't back down either. She reached out and gently dusted off some non-existent dust from Xu Qingzhu's shoulder, leaning close and lowering her voice: "Little cutie, why are you so hostile toward me?"

Xu Qingzhu stepped back one step, her brow furrowing like a small mountain.

"You're so beautiful, why is your heart so malicious?" Zhou Yi'an continued. "Can't I simply be here to find a job? After all, I graduated from a first-class foreign university's design department and have rich work experience."

"I worked at ME⁵ for a year and a half, and won RT's annual emerging designer award last year. Coming to work at your Minghui Jewelry, my qualifications are more than sufficient. Why can't you think that I'm here for charity work? Helping your company get out of trouble and return to its peak, to prove my abilities." At this point, Zhou Yi'an smiled lightly. "After all, Minghui Jewelry was once a legend in Haichuan City."

Xu Qingzhu's face clearly showed two words - disbelief.

She still had a lot of work to do later and was too lazy to argue with Zhou Yi'an here. She helped push Zhou Yi'an back to create distance between them, her voice becoming increasingly cold: "I hope Miss Zhou will do as she says."

Zhou Yi'an: "...?"

That's it?

She was still waiting for Xu Qingzhu to retort.

But Xu Qingzhu said: "I hope Designer Zhou's arrival will bring our Minghui Jewelry back from the dead."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

Footnotes:

1. **Qingyi University (青翼大學):** A fictional prestigious university in this story's setting.
2. **"Landlord's foolish son" (地主家的傻兒子):** A Chinese idiom referring to someone from a wealthy family who appears simple-minded or naive, often used to describe someone who seems oblivious to social situations.
3. **Haichuan City (海舟市):** The fictional city where this story takes place, literally meaning "Sea Boat City."
4. **"Like a bamboo standing alone in the world" (遺世獨立的竹子):** This metaphor draws on bamboo's cultural significance in Chinese literature as a symbol of resilience, integrity, and grace under pressure.
5. **ME:** Appears to be a prestigious international design company in this fictional world.